

SMALL GETS BIG

Instant connect, constant publicity and oodles of money make small screen the ideal destination for film stars. And as soaps stumble, channels pull in actors to win over the IPL-struck audience.

■ By Jhilmil Motihar

Drew Carrey has been receiving phone calls from an unlikely Indian dialer. Hollywood's funny man and the host of *Power of 10* has been giving Salman Khan tips on how to enthrall audiences as the anchor of *Power of 10*'s Indian avatar, or as Sony TV has rechristened it, *Dus Ka Dum*. Though infamous in tabloids as a maverick, Salman is anything but joking about his television debut. He possibly can't afford to since he's reportedly being paid a staggering Rs 90 crore for 100 episodes. Even before shooting for the show began, the actor took Synergy Adlabs, the production house, on a Mumbai tour, just so he could rehearse. "We've been travelling with him to Mehboob Studios, to his house and even to his brother's office," says Managing Director Anita Kaul Basu.

Till only a few years ago it would have been preposterous to think that a successful superstar would host a shot on television. Even Amitabh Bachchan's decision to sit opposite *Kaun Banega Crorepati*'s (KBC) hot seat in 2000, though a first for a film star, had come at a time when the actor was suffering from some serious down time. It was really with Shah Rukh Khan's KBC quizzing that people took notice. And though it has taken some time, Bollywood's boom time on television has only just begun. After the two Khans, Akshay Kumar, whose only previous television appearance was a seven-



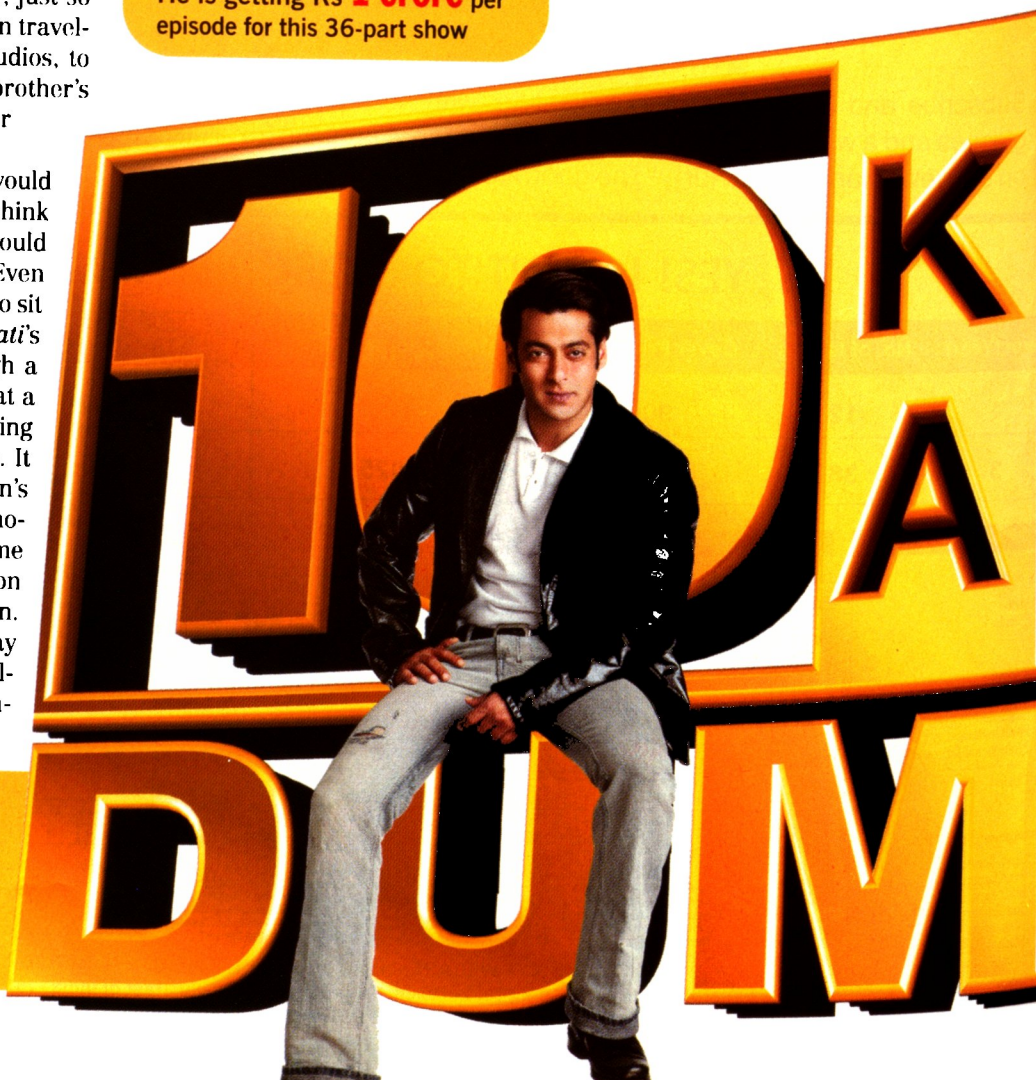
SHAH RUKH KHAN, PAANCHVI PAAS

He is getting Rs **1 crore** per episode for this 36-part show

part series on National Geographic called *Seven Deadly Arts*, has given his nod to host *Fear Factor*'s Indian version, not surprisingly called *Khatron Ke Khiladi*.

The 16-episode show, which will air on Viacom-18's recently launched channel Colors, is being produced by Endemol and the actor is reportedly being paid a whopping Rs 1.5 crore per episode. Though this is the second instalment of *Fear Factor* in India, the first one, aired on Sony TV, featured little-known small screen stars, was hosted by Mukul Dev, and made no more than a blip on the TRP graph (2.5).

The blitzkrieg of actors using television for their greater good started when



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